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Gen Z protests against corruption and social media ban spread across country

Violent clashes ensued in several places due to confrontations between the demonstrators and the security personnel.

A scene of anti-government protests organised by youths in Pokhara on Monday. **Post Photo**

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Published at : September 9, 2025 | Updated at : September 9, 2025 06:17 | Kathmandu

Gen Z protests against corruption and social media restrictions have intensified outside the Kathmandu Valley as well. Protests were launched in several districts across the country on Monday.

The protesters took to the streets in major cities and towns, including Damak, Birtamod, Itahari, Biratnagar, Janakpur, Bharatpur, Pokhara, Birgunj, Butwal, Bhairahawa, Tulsipur, and Dhangadhi, among others.

Violent clashes ensued in several places due to confrontations between the demonstrators and the security personnel.

In Sunsari, two people were killed and one was injured after police opened fire during a violent protest in front of the Itahari Sub-Metropolitan Office. Clashes erupted when demonstrators, who had gathered since 11 am, vandalised the main gate of the office, the mayor's chamber, and two nearby private houses. Several protesters and police officers injured in the clash are undergoing treatment in Damak Hospital. The deceased are yet to be identified.

Sunsari's Chief District Officer Dharmendra Mishra said that after Monday afternoon's protest turned violent, the Sunsari administration imposed a curfew from 3:30 pm in and around Itahari's main area.

In Jhapa's Birtamod and Damak, over a dozen people were injured as protesters clashed with police. Demonstrators set fire to vehicles at Birtamod's police post and pelted stones at Prime Minister KP Sharma Oli's residence in Damak, prompting police to fire warning shots.

Authorities imposed a curfew from 8:30 pm Monday to 5:00 am Tuesday across key areas of Birtamod.

Protests against the government spread to major towns, including Jhapa, Ilam, Dharan, Biratnagar, Janakpur, Rautahat, Birgunj, Sindhuli, Hetauda, Chitwan, Nawalparasi East, Dang, Surkhet, Kailali, Kanchanpur, and Dadeldhura.

Curfews were also enforced in Pokhara, Butwal, Bhairahawa, Itahari, Birtamod, and Gulariya to contain escalating unrest.

In most places, as Gen Z youths began protesting against the government—gathering around the time when college hours ended—other groups joined in, making the situation spiral out of control.

The Rupandehi District Administration Office imposed a curfew in Butwal and Bhairahawa from 4 pm to 10 pm on Monday following intensified Gen Z protests.

Chief District Officer Tokraj Pandey said the curfew has been enforced within designated zones, prohibiting any gatherings, rallies, protests, meetings, or sit-ins.

In Kaski, the district administration has imposed an indefinite curfew in Pokhara after clashes broke out during protests led by Gen Z demonstrators. The curfew was clamped down to bring the escalating situation under control.

Effective from 2 pm, the curfew bans gatherings of more than five people, rallies, and demonstrations within the city's core administrative zone. The restricted area stretches from Y-chowk in the east to the Fishtailgate in Baidam in the west, the Kaski Land Revenue Office in the north, and the Rastra Bank in the south—covering key government offices.

The protests intensified when demonstrators surrounded the Gandaki Province Chief Minister's Office, prompting police to use tear gas, rubber bullets, and water cannons to disperse the crowd. Clashes erupted after protesters vandalised government vehicles near the Chief Minister and Council of Ministers' Office. Two protesters sustained bullet injuries in the clash.

Authorities said the curfew would remain in place until further notice to prevent further violence and maintain public order.

In Chitwan, police fired tear gas and aerial shots to disperse youths protesting in front of the Bharatpur Metropolitan City Office. According to the administration, six protesters and four police personnel were injured, though all are in normal condition, Chief District Officer Ganesh Aryal said.

Amid rumours that some demonstrators were hit by bullets, Aryal clarified that no one was shot. "After protesters blocked police inside the office, tear gas was used to disperse them," he said.

However, the group "Gen-Z Chitwan, Youth Retaliation Against Corruption" stated that the afternoon protest in Bharatpur was not organised by them. In a statement issued on Monday, the group clarified that its programme was limited to 10:00 to 11:30 am in front of the District Administration Office.

"We submitted a memorandum and announced the conclusion of our programme. We have no knowledge of where the crowd went afterwards or who led and took responsibility for it," the statement read.

Sabin KC, a member of the group, added that their protest was against corruption, not about deactivating social media platforms.

In Kailali, a group of Gen Z demonstrators led by Sarita Joshi, a postgraduate student at Kailali Multiple Campus, began a protest in front of the Kailali District Administration Office at 10:30 am on Monday. Soon after, another group led by Roshan Joshi arrived at the same spot. While Sarita's group urged Roshan's group to join forces, the latter refused.

After staying briefly at the administration office, Roshan's group marched toward the Chief Minister's Office, chanting slogans. The demonstration soon turned aggressive, with protesters blocking vehicles, piling tires on roads, and even attempting to vandalise a nearby electricity transformer. Eyewitnesses said Roshan appeared to be leading these actions.

Security personnel tried to prevent damage to public property and maintain peace but failed as protesters continued marching through the Chief Minister's Office and its vicinity.

When the protest went out of control, Roshan and some others left the scene, while Sarita's group had already concluded its protest peacefully by noon.

Similarly, the protesters staged demonstrations in various places in Madhesh Province as well. They protested in Janakpur by burning tyres, demanding to control corruption and lift the ban on social media. Such demonstrations were also held in Chandranigahapur of Rautahat district.

In Khotang, demonstrators staged a protest in Diktel, starting from Triveni Chowk at noon and marching through Hatdanda, Basecamp, Ratnapark, and ending at Kirat Chowk. Students, teachers, and locals also joined the rally, voicing concerns over corruption, restrictions on online platforms, and youth opportunities.

(With inputs from our local correspondents)

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